

The Ten Commandments (Exodus 20)



1. You shall have no other gods before me.



2. You shall not make for yourself an idol and worship it.



3. You shall not misuse the name of the Lord your God.



4. Remember the Sabbath day and keep it holy.



5. Honor your father and your mother.



6. You shall not murder.



7. You shall not commit adultery.



8. You shall not steal.



9. You shall not give false testimony against your neighbor.



10. You shall not covet anything that belongs to your neighbor.

The Book of Deuteronomy, the fifth book of the Torah, is attributed to source D. It is associated with the religious reformation of King Josiah, who ruled the Israelite kingdom of Judah (formed after the northern and southern tribes divided, in c. 930 BCE) in the 7th century BCE. Josiah centralized Jewish worship in the Temple in Jerusalem and enforced strict monotheism. The northern kingdom, Israel, had been conquered by the Assyrians in 722 BCE, and in Deuteronomy, the history of Israel is rewritten as perceived from Judah.

The latest material, from source P, dates from after the Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar destroyed the city and Temple of Jerusalem in 586 BCE. He deported the Jewish leaders, including the priests, to Babylon, and there the priests revised the books of Genesis and Exodus and wrote Leviticus and Numbers. In the Priestly stories, Yahweh was not tied to one place but could accompany the Jews anywhere, including their

exile: "I will put my dwelling place among you ... I will walk among you and be your God, and you will be my people" (Leviticus 26:11–12).

Mosaic law evolved over time, being updated in response to new circumstances. Yet every new law was presented as having been given to Moses by God at Sinai.

One transcendent God

The early Israelites worshipped other Canaanite gods alongside Yahweh. In the Torah, there are many stories of Israelites worshipping Baal, the god of rain and fertility, and Asherah, the mother goddess. Yahweh and the other gods were worshipped at sanctuaries (holy places), often located on hilltops.

The First Commandment, "You shall have no other gods *before me*," could be read to mean that other deities may be worshipped, as long as Yahweh is honored above them. In the stories attributed to sources J and E, Yahweh appeared in human

form, "walking in the garden in the cool of the day" (Genesis 3:8) or visiting Abraham in front of his tent (Genesis 18). However, by the time Deuteronomy was written, God was transcendent, existing beyond the created world, and Judaism was a monotheistic religion. King Josiah, in the course of his religious reformation, removed the Asherah statues from the Temple in Jerusalem, burned them, and destroyed all the hilltop shrines.

Once Judaism became monotheistic, the earlier stories of Israelites worshipping Asherah and Baal were interpreted as examples of regression from Mosaic law. The Babylonian exile was now seen as divine punishment for this.

A nation of priests

During their exile in Babylon, the Jewish priests asserted that God had commanded the Israelites to be a holy people, a nation of priests, so that he could live among them. They